Year

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The bag bulges. Groceries press against the sides. The weight pulls at her hands. Straps narrow, pressed into the fold of a finger. A sharp edge there. She flinches once. Her eyelids tighten. Lashes meet, then open again.

She walks along the curb, carefully, one foot in front of the other, torso balanced to the narrow edge, close to falling. The bag shifts. A small swing across the hip. Lightness in the wrist. The bottom thinner, stretched by what is heavy. Through the film, outlines visible. Cartons. A jar. Something pressed against the side. She pauses. The bag keeps moving, slow. It swings against her leg.

At the corner, where the curb slants, she stops again. Cars slow down. Wheels turning less. The sound of them halved. Still the bag moves, slightly. A sign of waiting. For something. A car, a person.

She doesn't move. No headphones. No phone. Her face angled down. Eyes open. Cars pass. They pass slowly. Engines low. Windows reflecting. She waits. Then walks again. Her steps careful. The straps cut in. The weight draws lower. The plastic marked, pierced in some places. A point pressing sharp into her thigh. She doesn't move it.

At the curb she pauses once more. Toes over the edge. Cars press close. Then slow. At halt, eyes behind windshields. Waiting for her. She notices the moment. The bag swings once, then turns. It strikes her knee. The weight inside shifts. One carton slides. Then another. They fall. Groceries scatter. Across the curb. Toward the road.

She reaches, but the shapes hide in the corners of her eyes. Lights glare from above the windshield. She turns away. Someone passes near. A voice, not clear. She presses the bag to her chest. Picks up what she can. The rest stays scattered. Glass against the asphalt, a sharp sound.

The email said it was unusual. It said the light would be strong. Stronger than she was used to. She tried to picture it. A white glare. Being hidden beneath a cloth. She imagined air passing across the one part left uncovered, cool against the skin, while everything else stayed still and closed. Tears forming there, sliding across her temple. She lowered the laptop brightness, then raised it again. At its highest, some of the letters stood out clearly, while others seemed faint, as if pressed behind a thin fog. She thought of reading. The words moving in and out, some clear, some unreachable, as if carried away by weather. The email said there would be no pain. Only pressure. She tried to imagine what that meant. A hand close by. A shadow leaning across the light. A movement she would sense more than see. A sound. Small, sharp, like a click. She pictured the point where it would begin, somewhere hidden, right at the center. She tried to imagine keeping still while her body wanted to turn away.

It said it would be quick. Minutes. Perhaps less. She thought of minutes. How they thickened when she waited. In waiting rooms, with their plastic chairs and thin clocks. At home, with curtains drawn and the air unmoving. How fifteen minutes could stretch so wide it became another hour. The email said not to arrive earlier than that. She thought about waiting at home, the rooms themselves turning into a waiting area, quiet and dim, the minutes arriving one after another.

The email said not to lift. Not to bend. To let the body rest. She imagined herself in bed with curtains pulled, light pressing faintly through the edges, shapes doubled for a while before fading. She thought of days like that, not cooking, food arriving in bags, each delivery costing too much. The body kept still, conserving. At the end the email asked for feedback. She read it again. Closed the page. Opened it once more. The words had not changed, but she read them as though they might, slower this time, watching the shapes of the letters form and hold, waiting for them to shift.

Everything from below. The mattress low. It sat flat on the floor. Curtains touched the ground. Drawn, but not fully. A strip of light fell across the wall. Narrow at first. Then wider. Then dull. Dust moved inside it. Slow. A few particles carried. Then nothing. Gone. The wall returned to dimness. She had not been here for some time. The air felt different. Cold, but stale. A thickness, like it had been closed too long. Dry at the back of the throat. Not fresh, not used. The bed was flat. Sheets without shape. No mark from a body. No fold pressed into fabric. No heat left behind. Just cloth, level and untouched. A stillness that seemed held there, pressed into the cotton. On the table, a glass. Clear. Empty. At the base, a faint ring. White. She watched it for a while. The glass stayed, light shifting across its side. A shadow leaned from it onto the surface. The table bare. Corners with dust.

She placed the bag down. Empty. The sound thin, plastic against the floor. It peeled faintly, like skin. Then collapsed. The straps crossed, twisted. They stayed like that. Her hands carried the marks. Lines where the weight had pressed. Red fading. She rubbed once with her thumb. Then stopped. Let her arms rest in her lap. No food in the room. No smell of it. Not cooked. Not kept. Only detergent, faint. In clothes folded once, then left. A shirt. A pair of trousers. A small pile. Not ordered. Not disordered. Waiting.

She sat on the edge of the bed. The mattress sank slowly. Springs gave, a sound like air leaving. Then still. She stayed like that. Body unmoving. Shoulders low. Elbows to knees. Hands resting. Head bent. The light shifted. Fell further down the wall. Fainter. Into the corner. She followed it with her eyes. Blinked. The edges bent. Shapes doubled. A blur. Then cleared. Her breath stayed shallow. Hardly lifting her chest. The room listened.

A Fly on the window, its buzz a humming noise. The glass of the window vibrating to nearly noticeable. It flies against the glass. Over and over again, to exhaustion. Falling, laying there paralyzed. Only to set off again. By the strength of its wings, crawling the vertical wall. To fly into the glass. Its six legs tiny. Sticky hairs on their footpads. Holding it on the smooth surface of the window. Only gradually sinking lower. Before another flight against indiscernible. Just to fall onto the sill, lay there. Neck to the ground. Head turned. Ears anticipating hum of a fly's wings. For no answer.

She leaned further, her palms pressing into her knees. The mattress shifted softly, then settled. A crease formed in the sheet, narrow, diagonal. It stayed like that. Not moving. She thought of the straps of the bag, how they had cut the same way. Marks pressed and held, then fading slowly. The lines on her hands were gone now, though the skin felt bruised. The fly started again. Its sound filled the window space. The wings struck the glass with small vibrations, steady, irregular. She waited for it to stop, but it did not. A shadow trembled across the sill each time it lifted. A rhythm without progress. She listened, eyes half-closed. The hum rose, then fell back into silence. Then rose again. It wouldn't enter further into the room.

She looked to the strip of light on the wall. It had narrowed again, like the window had closed without her seeing it. The dust inside it no longer moved. Only a faint flicker when her eyes shifted. The light reminded her of the email, the lines about brightness. A white cloth. A glare. Minutes stretched long. She thought of that while watching the wall. The strip had almost faded. She blinked slowly. The bag lay against the floor where she had dropped it. Plastic collapsed inward, folding onto itself. It looked hollow now, its sides drawn together. As if it still carried the weight of something, though nothing remained. She leaned into her knees, palms pressing harder. The fly stopped. It lay near the sill. Legs curled slightly, still clinging, its wings folded in. Then, with no warning, it started again. A rush of sound, sudden against the silence. She flinched once, lashes meeting, then open again.

The fly stayed with her; even when she closed her eyes, even when sleep tried to take her, it remained, its wings striking the glass in a low, steady pulse—strike, pause, strike again—impossible to ignore. Her chest tightened. Breath came shallow, unsteady, yet she couldn't move. In the dark it grew. Not one fly. Not a single body. Many. A hum moved through the walls. Thickened in the corners. Vibrated in the pipes, in the metal of the bed frame, in the joints of the floorboards. The room contracted. Imperceptibly. The walls drew closer. The air thickened. Dampened. Heavy in the chest. The windows sweated with condensation. Breaths fogged the glass, blurred the edges of the room. Outside, rain slipped steadily down. Mild. Soft. Persistent. Nothing urgent. Still, it found its way inside. A seam in the wall. A crack in the plaster. Dark. Wet. Relentless. The mattress felt lower than before. The ceiling closer. The air between floor and ceiling dense, clinging. The sheets pressed to the body. The body pressed to the bed. Flat. Small. At the edge of the room, two windows. Beyond them, another space. Higher ceiling. Cooler air. Water gathered there, bulging downward, trembling under its own weight. When it fell, it fell without sound. Only a stain spread, darkening the floor, moving like a slow tide, like something alive. The flies returned. Heavy with water. Clinging. Struggling. Rasps of wings, wet and trembling, pressed against glass, against skin, against thought. Electricity hummed. Soft. Fleeting. Far. Fluorescent somewhere else. Supermarket aisles. White light. Standing in line. Waiting. A name called. Next. White chairs. A waiting room. Somewhere beyond the house. Somewhere beyond the room. Light burned further in. Harsh. White. Blinding. Like the email said. A cloth hung near it. Yet the glare escaped, bending around its edges, spilling into the room, into the walls. She thought of rows of beds, curtains drawn between them. Weeks of orderly food. Rain pressed through it all, persistent. Filling the mouth. Filling the chest. She tried to breathe. Tried again. The air heavy. Filled with forms she could not name. Weight she could not lift. She imagined herself at the desk. Filling out forms. Waiting. Did not move. Did not answer. A voice came. Through the curtains. Slow. Flat. Asking. Repeating. She could not tell if the words were hers. If the questions were hers. Or the bed next to hers, behind the curtain. She did not answer. Did not move. Did not breathe. The words continued. The quiet hum of a fly. Alive.

Bedroom next to living room. Small kitchen to the left. Bathroom beyond. No doctors. No nurses. Only a low pulse. Water dripping somewhere, somewhere out of sight. Air moving through vents. She felt it. The watching. Feeling. She imagined the walls bending, ceilings shifting. The air moving like water through corridors. She imagined herself walking. Barely moving. Groceries pressed to the chest. Leaving with the haste of humiliation. Men who watched. The time had thinned. She could not separate moments. Flies beating against glass. The body pressed flat. Sheets pressed flat. Light touched them.

The mattress shifted under her. Her hands lay still. Fingers touching nothing. The room smelled damp. The air thick with rain. She could feel it settling on the skin. The ceiling pressed down. The floor pressed up. Walls exhaled around her. Shadows shifted, imperceptible. The fly struck the glass again. A rhythm that held everything. She imagined the hum inside her chest. The pulse in her ears. The subtle vibration under the sheets. Water gathered in corners, ran along edges, left tiny streaks. Light bent around corners. Moved across walls. The body felt smaller, flatter. Every breath left a mark. The mattress caught it. The sheets pressed against it. The air pressed against them both. She imagined herself walking through the corridors. Barely moving. Past windows, past doors, past walls that breathed. The floor hummed underfoot. The air clung to her skin. Flies struggled against the glass, their wings soft as drums. Words stretched thin. She did not move. Did not answer. She pressed her hands to the sheets. The air heavy. Full of water, of light, of sound she could not name.

Only breathing, hearing the pulse of wings. The drip of water. The bend of light. The room contained her. Held her small body. Every surface pressed close. Every sound contained. The fly struck the glass. The mattress shifted. The ceiling leaned. The walls closed fractionally. The air pressed against her chest. She tried to follow her breath. Felt it heavy. Felt it slow. Felt it pass through her fingers. She did not move. Did not answer. Did not lift her head. The fly struck the bedroom window again.

The payment didn't go through. The system is new. It happens all the time. She types the numbers. Taking the card in hand. Holding it longer this time. A circle appears. Turns as they wait. The wrinkles around her lips tense then fall. She doesn't say. She gives her the card back. It's hard to see on the little screen. Her eyes stay on the card reader. There is no thank you. She takes the card back with her left hand. Her right hand's fingers slip off the other cards in her wallet. She's trying to pull them out of the fold. She hides this below the desk. The card from before still in the other hand. With no where to put it, but the pocket of her pants. Now that it's free. She wipes the sweat off her left hand. Focuses again on the wallet. Her hands pulsating. The cards in the wallet move now. She looks up and gives one of them to the woman behind the desk. She takes it between two fingers. Holds it. The reader is black. She types on it. Nothing. "It does that", putting her card down on the desk.

She stands there. The woman behind the desk left. Her hands are wet again. She puts her wallet in the back pocket of her pants. To dry off both hands. Finds the card from earlier in one of the pockets. Looks at it. A sound. First quiet then clearer. A be right back, from behind one of the staff doors. Then nothing. She stands there waiting. Takes out her wallet and puts the card she found back in one of the folds. Then let's the whole thing sink back into a pocket. With all hands free and her gone. She moves her arms around. In a slow swinging motion. She does this for some time. There are little sounds like searching from the back. She slows down what she's doing. No one comes. The dry air loosened up her hands. Sounds again but no one comes. The card on the desk is still there. She examines it. Goes from foot to foot. Her hands go wet again. She does the slow motion. A wind around her. The doorknob goes.

The same woman comes again. The wrinkles around her lips indicate a smile. "Sorry for the waiting". She puts down the reader. Bright again. Types down the sum from earlier and turns it around. Notices the card on the desk. "This one?". A nod in return. Holds it for some time. Shorter than before. A sound from the machine. She shrinks her shoulders. "Sorry". The skin on her chin glows. She looks at the woman behind the desk. The air around her still. She feels the inside of one of the pockets. The fabric there is wet. Her hand goes to the wallet. She takes it out. Waits for her to pass the card that didn't pay. She pauses. Reaches out. Puts it back with the others. "Strange".

"It happens". The system is new. She said she preferred the ones where you could still insert the card. Her hands do the same movement as earlier, only smaller. The air is thick. She moves around. Goes to one of the staff doors. She waits. The wallet still in her hands. The card didn't fit right into the fold, she chose in the hurry. Corrects it. The shop is empty. The light of the card reader goes dimmer then dark again. The woman behind the desk waits. It doesn't light up. ''Battery". Goes off again to the door that says Staff only. Sounds of searching again. She does the movement from earlier. Hands touch the air around. Dry a little. She feels for her wallet. Still there. She looks at the doors. She comes back. ''Sorry", again. The desk in front of her is almost empty now. She took and left the reader behind one of the doors. It doesn't work or it's the cards. There isn't enough cash in hand. Her eyebrows seem different than before. Eyes not as open. Hands search a pocket. She pauses, looks to the corner. Her feet turning. Towards the door behind her, the entry. It's made of glass. The writing on it, the other way around. Windscreen repair.

The woman behind the desk asks. Her lips form the same low smile. There is an ATM not far. She looks at her, nodding. She sees her eyes shifting to the doors. She doesn't stand still. The shop is all empty. There aren't any customers, now that she left.

The first examination, state-mandated. He left early. The street was quiet. Cars. Their movement distant and outside. Pale walls on either side. Squared windows. A sign with letters peeling. Stopped outside the entrance. Stood for a while. Looked at the door. Waited. Then stepped inside the waiting room. Almost empty. Chairs in a line against the wall. Small. Hard. Plastic. No thought for comfort. The smell of antiseptic. A stack of forms lay on the counter. Bent at the corners. The receptionist kept her eyes down. Flipped through the papers, one by one. Slowly. Not looking up. The sound of the paper soft. He listened. Each page the same. Her hand hardly moved. A direction pointed. He sat. The chair creaked. Then stilled. Thin silence. Stretched wide. Someone coughed. The sound carried, then fell away. He thought of the "remember", he was told. Half warning. Half joke. The words stayed. Without meaning. His name was called. The sound cut through the silence. He stood, walked. A short corridor. The floor firm underfoot. The light above hummed. The hum louder than his steps. The room was bare. White walls. No decoration. A poster about blood pressure. Curled at the edges. A stretcher under a lamp. Its light harsh. The chair by the desk creaked as he moved it.

The man stood waiting. Tall, slim. Clipboard in hand. His voice calm. Steady. He asked questions. Injuries. Any severe. Do you smoke. Drink. Drugs. Sexual activity. His voice did not pause. Each word followed the last. He answered. Briefly. He nodded. Wrote in small marks. Slow. Neat. The pen scratched the paper. Louder than his voice. He was asked to remove his shirt.

To breathe. In. Out. Regular rhythm. The stethoscope pressed cold. Then less. His expression did not shift. He listened. Then wrote again. Pen scratching. The sound filled the room. He stepped on to the treadmill. The machine started. Low whir. His steps heavy. Louder than they should have been. His notes quiet, precise. Line by line. Blood was drawn. The tube filled slowly. Capped. Set aside. His hands steady. The same work, repeated many times. He was only half there. Watching his hands. Watching the pen. Watching the small movements that repeated, one after the other.

When it ended, he looked up. "Thank you for your time." The words flat. Final. Without weight. Without emphasis. He handed a brochure. Laser treatments. Local clinics. "Saving up myself," he said. His words quick. Almost casual. "It only takes a few seconds. People say it feels like rebirth". His smile brief. Forced. Then gone. He offered his hand. Cold. Damp. The chair creaked again. Lowered eyes, a murmured ''thanks''. Walked out. Past the counter. Into the corridor.

The words stayed. Should've said there's no money. Should've said the eyes are too far gone. But didn't. Walked out. The door shut behind. The silence the same

as before. The whole thing over before it had even begun. Ten minutes. Maybe less.